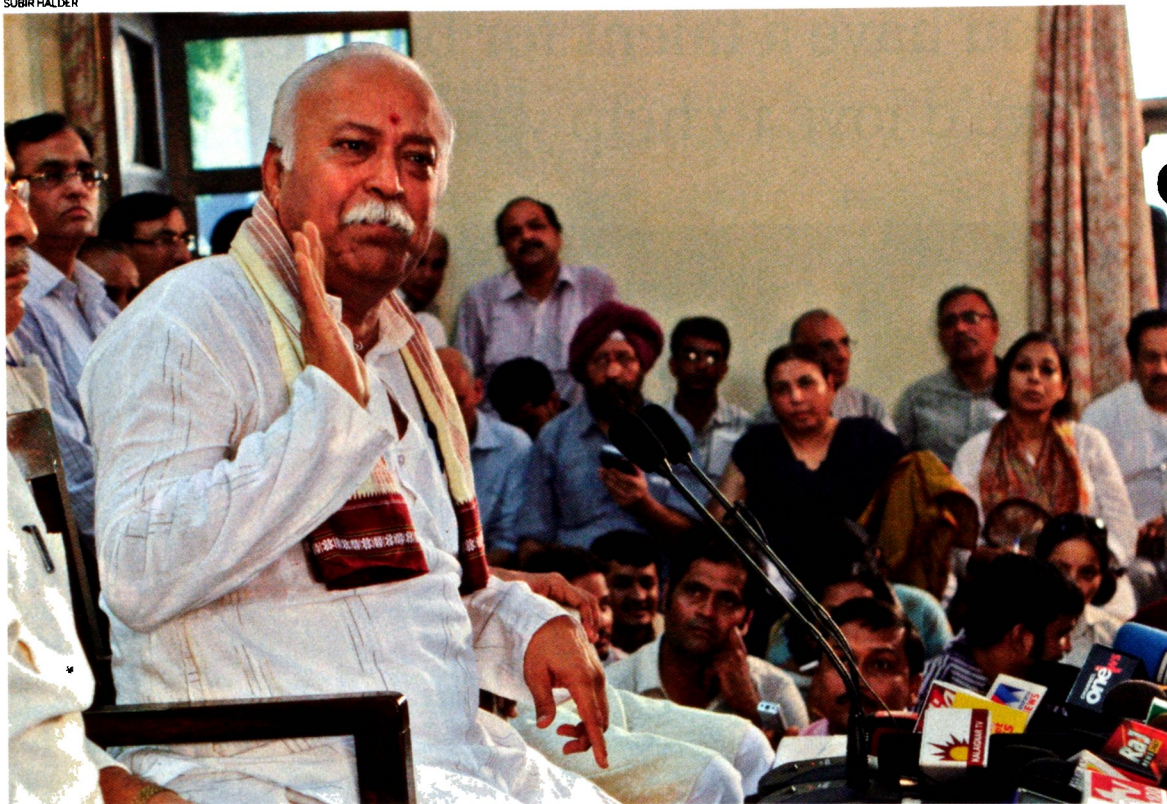


SUBIR HALDER



MOHANRAO BHAGWAT SEEMS TO HAVE ENJOYED HIS STATUS AS THE MOST SOUGHT AFTER SOUNDBITE GURU

THE SANGH'S ROLE AS THE FINAL ARBITER OF THE BJP'S destiny may have restored peace but it has also strengthened the stereotype: the party's independence is conditional.

traditional structures of the party, it was a campaign sustained by his fantasy and a select few non-political freelancers. Ideally, he should have been just the campaigner, not the candidate. Advani on the stump was not exactly the face of 21st century India—or of a 21st century Right-wing party. He turned the election into a referendum on himself and the answer was a resounding no. Still he refused to read the message that he has overstayed, that the time has come for a total generational shift. Defeat only intensified his hallucination about political immortality, and he took refuge in make-believe. He has become the patron saint of a cabal, each member a protégé of his. They are united in projecting him as the indispensable one because each of them doesn't want the other as the next leader. So the BJP today has a president whose freedom is purely ceremonial. (Rajnath's only show of authority was the sacking of Jaswant.) The real power is with an urban Brahminical elite. Advani himself declared that the BJP chief ministers will not be "disturbed". He has been distancing himself from ideologically driven grassroots leaders—be it Kalyan Singh or Uma Bharati—from the hinterlands since the late 1990s. He

abandoned the constituency that made him and desperately sought the approval of the one that doesn't vote for him anyway.

He has now reached a stage where he has nowhere to turn for one last vote of conscience. In the wake of the post-Jaswant mutiny, he has only succeeded in bringing the RSS to the centre of the party affairs. Mohanrao Bhagwat, the media-savvy RSS boss with that camera-friendly walrus moustache, seems to have enjoyed his status as the most sought after soundbite guru. Still, the high profile role of the Sangh as the final arbiter of the BJP's destiny may have restored peace in the House of Saffron, but it has also strengthened the stereotype: the party's independence is conditional. It has further added to the image crisis of the BJP. It is perhaps the final revenge of Lal Krishna Advani. On September 12, 1947, the 20-old swayamsevak left his hometown of Karachi for Delhi on a BOAC aircraft. He had to flee because many of his colleagues were arrested after a bomb blast in the city. Six momentous decades later, it is again farewell time. Doesn't he like travelling, even if it is on the high road of desolation?

with Bhavna Vij-Aurora and Shyamal Yadav